

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Inspected Trust

1. Mindset Shift: From Blind Trust to Inspected Trust

- ☐ Avoid relying on trust alone as a management technique
- ☐ Separate **judgment/process quality** from **outcomes**
- ☐ Recognize the four categories of performance:
 - Good process + Good decision + Good outcome
 - Good process + Good decision + Bad outcome (good error)
 - Bad process + Bad decision + Good outcome (bad success)
 - Bad process + Bad decision + Bad outcome
- ☐ Treat inspection as support and accountability — not suspicion
- ☐ View discomfort with inspection as a signal to explore alignment issues

2. Avoid Common Trust Pitfalls

- ☐ Don't assume your initial "trust reservoir" will sustain itself
- ☐ Avoid letting new leaders "thrash" without feedback
- ☐ Don't confuse empowerment with the absence of oversight
- ☐ Intervene early before misalignment compounds
- ☐ Prevent "damage before feedback" cycles

3. Practice Inspected Trust ("Trust First, Then Verify")

When concerns arise:

- ☐ Assume there may be a real issue
- ☐ Independently validate the situation
- ☐ Seek multiple perspectives (cross-functional if needed)
- ☐ Consider missing context
- ☐ Form your own view before prescribing solutions
- ☐ Close the loop with the original reporter after validation

4. Use Effective Inspection Tools

A. Inspection Forums

- ☐ Establish weekly or monthly metric review forums
- ☐ Track goals regularly (avoid quarterly-only reviews)
- ☐ Ensure executive engagement and buy-in
- ☐ Focus on outcomes *and* process quality

B. Learning Spikes

- ☐ Go directly to individuals doing the work
- ☐ Talk across functions
- ☐ Avoid relying solely on summarized narratives
- ☐ Look for omitted context or filtered information

C. Engage Directly with Data

- ☐ Don't rely exclusively on heavily prepared summaries
- ☐ Understand how the data was prepared
- ☐ Identify potential bias in reporting
- ☐ Cross-reference new information against known sources

D. Intolerance for Misalignment

- ☐ Investigate confusion immediately
- ☐ Dig into unclear decisions or contradictory statements
- ☐ Resolve ambiguity before it compounds
- ☐ Treat persistent confusion as a trust risk

5. Introducing Inspection Into a Low-Inspection Culture

- ☐ Start with 1–2 critical problems (don't expand everywhere at once)
- ☐ Confirm executive peer tolerance before rollout
- ☐ Frame inspection as a long-term investment in team success
- ☐ Be explicit that the inspection ≠ distrust
- ☐ Expect and withstand defensive reactions
- ☐ Reinforce that feedback is part of leadership maturity

6. Protect and Build Real Trust

- ☐ Pair trust with validation
- ☐ Catch errors early to enable learning
- ☐ Reward strong process even when outcomes fail
- ☐ Avoid mistaking good errors for incompetence
- ☐ Avoid rewarding bad successes
- ☐ Make inspection reciprocal (allow your work to be inspected too)

7. Ongoing Leadership Habits

- ☐ Regularly evaluate leadership bench strength based on judgment, not the randomness of outcomes
- ☐ Maintain small, diverse data sources
- ☐ Continually clarify strategy and alignment
- ☐ Treat inspection as a gift — taking the work seriously
- ☐ Stay consistent even when inspection feels uncomfortable

Quick Self-Assessment

Ask yourself quarterly:

- ☐ Am I relying on trust alone anywhere?
- ☐ Where might I be mistaking outcomes for judgment?
- ☐ What misalignments am I tolerating?
- ☐ Where do I need a learning spike?
- ☐ Are my inspection forums producing clarity or just preparation work?